

project. Iterate over it multiple times and revise it before submitting it to a publisher. Note that this is the key step in the publication process, so it would be good if you could put in considerable effort and focus on this task.

Step 4: Contact an editor

When trying to contact the editor of a publishing firm that you are targeting, check the publishers' LinkedIn page, website or look for the editors' names in the front few pages of the competing books. Send the BPF you have prepared with a couple of sample chapters, by email. If possible, talk to the editor over the phone to get some inputs before submitting the final proposal.

Step 5: Sign the contract and follow the production process

Once the publisher accepts the BPF, an 'acquisitions editor' will send you a contract. Check the terms before signing the contract. Then, deliver the draft on the date you had promised in the contract. Once copy-editing and proof-reading is done, provide your inputs for the cover page design, sign the copyright documents, etc. Traditional publishers have documents that explain the book production process and 'developmental editors' are also typically very helpful. So you don't need to worry too much if you don't understand the book production process. At this stage, just be mentally prepared to learn about the book production process and follow it.

Step 6: Celebrate your success

This may sound cheesy, but the best part of writing a book is getting it out in the market. *So celebrate!*

Step 7: Aggressively promote the book

Wait, you are not done yet! There is one more step; you need to aggressively promote your book. Here are some ideas:

- Request potential reviewers to write reviews (in magazines, blogs or *Amazon.com*)
- Reach out to potential bulk purchasers of your book (such as libraries and training institutes)
- Reach out to your readers (by writing articles, speaking at conferences, etc)
- Promote your book online (create a supporting book website, tweet or blog)

You may find it uncomfortable promoting yourself. But ask yourself this question, "If I don't tell the world about my book, how will readers know about it and buy it?" If you don't spread the word about your book, who else will? So, relax. It is okay to blow your own trumpet once in a while!

Book writing: facts and fallacies

There are many myths and fallacies about book writing. Consider these:

- **You must be a born writer to write a book:** Fallacy.

Anyone can write a book (just as the rat Remy becomes a chef just by believing in the saying that 'Anyone can cook!' in the movie *Ratatouille*). As Henry Ford said: "Whether you think you can or think you can't ... you are right!"

- **You can become super rich by writing a book:** Fallacy. Of course there are exceptions such as J K Rowling who made a fortune out of the Harry Potter books. But we are talking about technical books here -- they don't sell in millions. Yes, you can make money, but not get super rich by writing a book.
- **There is only one correct way to write a book:** Fallacy. There are different ways to write a book. The writing approach that works for me may not work for you. So, find what works for you and stick with it. The following table lists the two different (but equally acceptable) ways to write the book.

Start from the first chapter	Take random notes and later 'stitch' them together
Work in a quiet place for days together	No dedicated time - write whenever there is some free time
Directly type in a word processor	Write it in a notebook and then type it in a word processor
Directly write it in the book format	Create presentations or write articles and later convert it into a book
Get acceptance from publisher and then start working on the contents	Complete the draft and then reach out to the publishers

- **You need to learn to use specialised writing tools before you write a book:** Fallacy. Perhaps this is the most common myth about writing a book. To start with, word processing software (such as OpenOffice) is more than enough for writing your first book. Of course, there are many tools that can aid in your writing process and that can help improve your productivity. As you gain expertise as a writer, you can start to using such tools.

Tips for book writing

Based on hard-earned experience in writing books, here is a list of some tips to get started with writing your first book.

Tip 1. Plan ahead and allocate time to write your book

Most first-time authors underestimate the effort required to write a book. Here is a rule of thumb: if your initial estimate is X months to write your book, make it 2X months—that would be a realistic estimate of the time required to complete writing your book!

Tip 2. It takes a team to write a book - so find a co-author(s)

It typically takes many months (sometimes years) to